



Celebrating success

This enamelled aluminum badge commemorates the "5-8" victory of August 5, 1964—Operation Pierce Arrow, during which the first US planes were shot down—and was later awarded to NVA soldiers who shot down US aircraft.

A tough fight

North Vietnam began to send NVA units southward in earnest in 1959. They also encouraged insurgent activity by the National Liberation Front (Viet Cong) in South Vietnam; and coordinated the war effort between the two. Like their American counterparts, soldiers in the NVA served a long way from home, but their tours of duty were indefinite. The journey into South Vietnam was occasionally undertaken by truck but more often, especially during the early years, involved long marches over rugged terrain. Although trail workers deferred to soldiers for rations and shelter, conditions were still extremely harsh. After surviving months on the trail, NVA soldiers often lived exposed to the elements in temporary encampments, dark tunnels, and cramped bunkers.